

GALLANT IAS ACADEMY
PRELIMS CUM MAINS BATCH 2027
ANCIENT INDIA
MODULE 3
THE VEDIC CULTURE - SUMMARY

Rig Vedic Age vs Later Vedic Age

POLITY

Aspect	Rig Vedic Polity	Later Vedic Polity
Time period	c. 1500-1000 BCE	c. 1000-600 BCE
Political character	Tribal chiefdom based on kinship	Transition towards territorial kingdoms
Political unit	Jana or tribe; vis and grama were smaller units	Janapada, rashtra and rajya became important
Ruler	Rajan was primarily a tribal chief and war leader	King became a more powerful territorial ruler
Nature of kingship	Hereditary tendency existed, but traces of election by the samiti remained	Kingship became increasingly hereditary; primogeniture gained strength
Powers of ruler	Limited by tribal customs and assemblies	Royal power increased at the expense of assemblies
Main duties	Protected the tribe and cattle, led wars and offered prayers	Protected territory, collected tribute and performed royal sacrifices
Assemblies	Sabha, samiti, vidatha and gana were influential	Vidatha disappeared; sabha and samiti survived but declined
Composition of assemblies	Wider tribal participation; women could attend the sabha and vidatha	Dominated by chiefs, nobles, Brahmanas and warriors; women excluded from the sabha
Officials	Few officials - purohita, senani, gramani and vrajapati	Priest, commander, chief queen, collector and other functionaries became important
Revenue	Bali was mainly a voluntary offering ; no regular taxation	Bali gradually became a compulsory tribute ; collection became more common
Army	No standing army; tribal militia was mobilised during war	Still no permanent standing army; tribal units continued to be mobilised
Nature of warfare	Mainly for cattle and tribal supremacy - gavishthi	Increasingly for territory, succession and political supremacy
Major political centres	Bharatas, Purus, Tritsus and other tribes	Larger formations such as Kuru-Panchala emerged

State formation	No proper territorial or civil administration	Movement towards state formation, but not yet a fully developed state with regular taxation and a standing army
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ECONOMY

Aspect	Rig Vedic Economy	Later Vedic Economy
Basic character	Predominantly pastoral and semi-nomadic	Predominantly agricultural and settled
Main wealth	Cattle were the chief measure of wealth	Land, crops, cattle and agricultural surplus gained importance
Cattle	Wars were frequently fought for cows; gavishthi meant 'search for cows'	Cattle remained important but were increasingly used in agriculture and sacrifices
Agriculture	Known but secondary; sowing, harvesting and threshing were practised	Agriculture became the chief means of subsistence
Plough	Probably a simple wooden ploughshare	Larger wooden ploughs, sometimes pulled by many oxen
Crops	Barley was important	Barley continued; rice, wheat and lentils became important
Metals	Ayas generally indicated copper or bronze; pre-iron economy	Iron, called shyama/krishna ayas, became increasingly known
Use of iron	Not characteristic of the Rig Vedic economy	Mainly used for weapons and probably axes; very few iron agricultural tools have been found
Land ownership	Land was not a well-established form of private property	Control over cultivable land and territory became more important
Settlements	Semi-mobile tribal settlements; no cities	Permanent settlements associated with Painted Grey Ware expanded
Crafts	Carpenter, chariot-maker, weaver, potter and leatherworker	Specialised smiths, smelters, jewellers, potters, carpenters and weavers
Trade	No clear evidence of regular organised trade; land routes dominated	Commerce expanded slowly; references occur to seas and sea voyages
Urbanisation	No real towns; pur did not necessarily mean a city	Hastinapura and Kaushambi showed proto-urban beginnings
Surplus	Limited surplus; little scope for regular tribute	Agricultural surplus supported chiefs, princes, priests and specialised artisans
Redistribution	Cattle, horses, chariots and war booty were distributed	Tribute and sacrificial gifts increasingly supported rulers and Brahmanas

SOCIETY

Aspect	Rig Vedic Society	Later Vedic Society
Basic character	Tribal, kinship-based and relatively egalitarian	Settled, agrarian, hierarchical and increasingly varna-divided
Social unit	Jana → vis → grama → griha	Territorial settlements and more regular households
Family	Large joint and patriarchal family	Patriarchal authority became stronger
Father's position	Father headed the household	Father could even disinherit his son
Succession	Kinship remained central	Primogeniture became stronger, especially in ruling families
Varna	Occupational differentiation had begun but was not rigid	Four varnas became clearly defined
Social divisions	Priests, warriors and common tribesmen; Shudra appeared only towards the end	Brahmana, Kshatriya, Vaishya and Shudra formed a graded hierarchy
Brahmanas	Priests were influential but not yet a fully dominant social order	Ritual expansion greatly increased Brahmana power
Kshatriyas	Tribal chiefs and warriors	Ruling and warrior aristocracy
Vaishyas	Emerged from the common tribal people or vis	Main producers - farmers, cattle-breeders, artisans and later traders; paid tribute
Shudras	Appeared towards the end of the Rig Vedic period	Placed in a serving position and denied several ritual privileges
Occupations	Comparatively flexible; members of one family could follow different occupations	Increasing specialisation and association of functions with varna
Slavery	Mainly female domestic slaves; not used extensively in production	Service inequality increased, especially in the position assigned to Shudras
Gotra	Not properly established	Gotra became important and gotra exogamy developed
Ashrama system	Not developed	First three stages were becoming defined; sannyasa was not yet fully established
Degree of rigidity	Social inequalities existed, but society remained largely tribal	Hierarchy strengthened, though varna distinctions were not yet completely rigid

Central social transition: Kinship-based tribal society → agrarian surplus → dominant Brahmana-Kshatriya orders → tribute-paying Vaishyas and serving Shudras.

POSITION OF WOMEN

Aspect	Rig Vedic Women	Later Vedic Women
General position	Comparatively better, though society was patriarchal	Position generally declined and subordination increased
Political participation	Could attend the sabha and vidatha	Excluded from the sabha
Religious participation	Offered sacrifices along with husbands	Participation became more restricted by priest-controlled rituals
Intellectual role	Women composed Rig Vedic hymns	Some exceptional women continued to participate in philosophical discussions
Examples	Apala, Ghosha, Lopamudra and Vishvavara	Women theologians appear in philosophical traditions; some queens joined coronation rituals
Education	Hymn composition shows intellectual and religious participation	Towards the end, women were denied upanayana and the Gayatri mantra
Marriage	Marriage was established; no evidence of child marriage in Sharma's account	Marriage was increasingly regulated through lineage and gotra rules
Marriage age	Sharma places the probable marriageable age around 16-17	No comparable general age is specified by Sharma
Widow remarriage	Widow remarriage and levirate were known	Sources cited here do not establish their complete disappearance
Family authority	Patriarchal; sons were preferred	Father's and husband's authority became stronger
Ritual importance	Wife participated with her husband in sacrifice	Chief queen retained ritual importance, but ordinary women had lower status
Overall assessment	Relatively greater participation, not equality	General decline, but not total exclusion

Avoid the extreme statement that Rig Vedic women enjoyed 'complete equality.' The society was already patriarchal and showed a preference for sons.

RELIGION

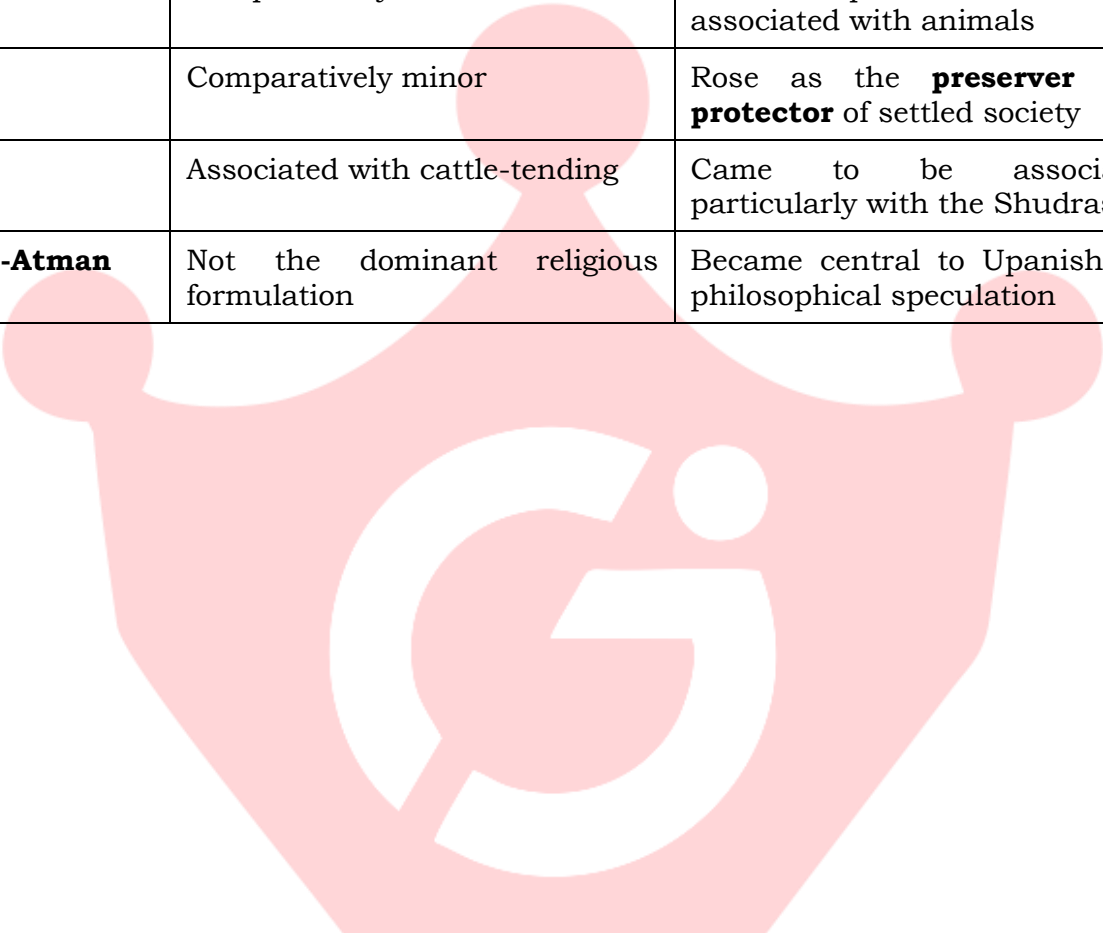
Aspect	Rig Vedic Religion	Later Vedic Religion
Basic character	Nature-centred and comparatively simple	Ritualistic, sacrificial and priest-dominated
Objects of worship	Natural forces personified as deities	Creator, protector and animal-related deities gained prominence
Main method	Recitation of hymns and prayers	Elaborate sacrifices accompanied by precise ritual formulae

Sacrifices	Collective and individual but comparatively simple	Large public and domestic sacrifices
Offerings	Barley, vegetables and other offerings	Cattle, horses, gold, cloth and other valuable gifts
Purpose	Cattle, children, food, rain, health, victory and long life	Material prosperity continued, along with royal power and social order
Priests	Important as purohitas, but worship retained a tribal character	Brahmanas claimed specialised and increasingly monopolistic ritual knowledge
Ritual formulae	Not elaborate; magical power of words was less important	Correct pronunciation and formulae were considered essential
Royal religion	Raja prayed and sacrificed for the tribe	Rajasuya, ashvamedha and vajapeya legitimised royal authority
Animal sacrifice	Present but less elaborate	Became extensive and consumed considerable cattle wealth
Social connection	Worship often involved the tribe collectively	Rituals strengthened Brahmana and Kshatriya dominance
Image symbolism	Worship focused primarily on hymns and sacrifices	Signs of worshipping objects as divine symbols appeared
Philosophical development	Material prayers dominated	Upanishadic thought questioned ritualism
New ideas	Limited concern with abstract spiritual liberation	Ideas of Atman, Brahman, knowledge and immortality developed
Reaction to ritualism	Not prominent	Upanishads stressed knowledge and right belief over excessive ritual

GODS

God / Deity Group	Rig Vedic Position	Later Vedic Position
Indra	Most important god; warlord, rain-god and Purandara	Lost much of his earlier supremacy
Agni	Second most important; fire-god and intermediary carrying offerings to gods	Continued in sacrifices but lost his former leading position
Varuna	Guardian of natural or cosmic order and associated with water	No longer among the most dominant gods
Soma	God connected with plants and the sacred intoxicating drink	Continued in ritual tradition but was less politically prominent
Maruts	Personifications of storms	Less prominent

Sarasvati	Important river goddess	Continued as a sacred figure, but not described as the supreme Later Vedic deity
Usha and Aditi	Female divinities were present, though male gods dominated	No major elevation comparable to Prajapati, Rudra and Vishnu is identified by Sharma
Prajapati	Not the supreme Rig Vedic deity	Became the supreme creator deity
Rudra	Comparatively minor	Gained importance as the god associated with animals
Vishnu	Comparatively minor	Rose as the preserver and protector of settled society
Pushan	Associated with cattle-tending	Came to be associated particularly with the Shudras
Brahman-Atman	Not the dominant religious formulation	Became central to Upanishadic philosophical speculation



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